



CITIES OF REFUGE AND THE LEVITES

The six cities of refuge and the forty-eight cities of the Levites · Joshua 20–21 · c. 1400 BC

THE SIX CITIES OF REFUGE

Where one who had killed a person accidentally might flee from the avenger of blood and live, until he stood before the congregation (Numbers 35:9–15; Joshua 20:1–6). Three were set apart by Moses east of the Jordan and three by Joshua west of it; all six were cities of the Levites.

West of the Jordan	Josh 20:7
Kedesh in Galilee <i>Naphtali</i>	F 1
Shechem <i>Ephraim</i>	E 7
Kirjath Arba, which is Hebron <i>Judah</i>	D 10
East of the Jordan	Deut 4:43; Josh 20:8
Bezer <i>Reuben</i>	G 9
Ramoth in Gilead <i>Gad</i>	H 5
Golan in Bashan <i>Manasseh</i>	H 3

THE FORTY-EIGHT CITIES OF THE LEVITES

Given by lot from every tribe, each with its common-lands (Numbers 35:1–8; Joshua 21:1–42). Where 1 Chronicles 6:54–81 names a city otherwise, its name follows in *italic*.

● The sons of Aaron, the priests	21:4, 9–19
from Judah and Simeon	21:9–16
Hebron	D 10
Libnah [†]	B 10
Jattir	C 11
Eshtemoa	C 11
Holon [†] <i>Hilen</i>	C 10
Debir	C 11
Ain [†] <i>Ashan</i>	B 11
Juttah <i>not in 1 Chr 6</i>	C 11
Beth Shemesh	C 9
from Benjamin	21:17–18
Gibeon <i>not in 1 Chr 6</i>	D 9
Geba	D 9
Anathoth [†]	D 9
Almon [†] <i>Alemeth</i>	D 9
■ The rest of the Kohathites	21:5, 20–26
from Ephraim	21:20–22
Shechem	E 7
Gezer	C 9
Kibzaim [†] <i>Jokneam</i>	F 7
Beth Horon	D 8
from Dan	21:23–24
Eltekeh [†] <i>not in 1 Chr 6</i>	B 8
Gibbethon [†] <i>not in 1 Chr 6</i>	B 9
Aijalon [†]	C 9
Gath Rimmon [†]	B 7
from the half-tribe of Manasseh	21:25
Tanach <i>Aner</i>	D 5
Gath Rimmon [†] <i>Bileam</i>	E 5

▲ The Gershonites	21:6, 27–33
from the other half of Manasseh, in Bashan	21:27
Golan in Bashan[†]	H 3
Be Eshterah [†] <i>Ashtaroth</i>	H 3
from Issachar	21:28–29
Kishion [†] <i>Kedesh</i>	E 4
Daberath [†]	E 4
Jarmuth [†] <i>Ramoth</i>	F 4
En Gannim [†] <i>Anem</i>	F 4
from Asher	21:30–31
Mishal [†] <i>Mashal</i>	D 3
Abdon	D 2
Helkath [†] <i>Hukok</i>	D 4
Rehob [†]	D 3
from Naphtali	21:32
Kedesh in Galilee[†]	F 1
Hammoth Dor [†] <i>Hammon</i>	F 3
Kartan [†] <i>Kirjathaim</i>	F 1
◆ The Merarites	21:7, 34–40
from Zebulun	21:34–35
Jokneam <i>not in 1 Chr 6</i>	D 4
Kartah [†] <i>not in 1 Chr 6</i>	<i>not mapped</i>
Dimnah [†] <i>Rimmon</i>	E 3
Nahalal [†] <i>Tabor</i>	D 4
from Reuben	21:36–37
Bezer[†]	G 9
Jahaz [†] <i>Jahzah</i>	G 10
Kedemoth [†]	G 11
Mephaath [†]	G 11
from Gad	21:38–39
Ramoth in Gilead	H 5
Mahanaim [†]	F 7
Heshbon [†]	G 9
Jazer [†]	G 8

ON THIS MAP

⬆	a city of refuge, ringed; its name in bold
Name [†]	a site in doubt: OpenBible.info rates it under 700 in 1,000 (33 of the 48); the scores are on page 2
—	tribal border, as on the Allotment Map (Joshua 13–19)
- - -	border between named landmarks, route estimated
- · - · -	Simeon's cities inside Judah (Joshua 19:1, 9)
—	perennial river
—	stream, in the rainy season
- · - · -	wadi, dry but after rain
■	sea or lake
■	marsh
—	contours, 100 m; 500 m heavier
▲ 1208 m • 835 m	summit; spot height, metres

THE GROUND the Base Map's natural cover, modelled for c. 2000 BC; the waters as in Joshua's day, the Salt Sea over its southern basin

■ forest and maquis	■ park forest of oak and carob	■ lote-bush scrub; Christ-thorn	■ semi-steppe batha
■ steppe; with terebinth	■ desert; acacia savannoid	■ Hermon forest; thorny cushions	■ reeds, riverside thicket
■ oasis	■ sand; coastal sand, uncertain	■ salt marsh and salt flat	■ lava field (basalt ground)
■ fixed sand with wormwood			

Base Map of this project at 1:1,000,000 (relief and contours from the Copernicus GLO-30 DEM, European Space Agency 2021; its other sources on the second page). Sites: OpenBible.info Bible Geocoding data (CC BY 4.0). Borders: the Allotment Map, a reconstruction from the boundary towns of Joshua 13–19. Names and verses: the New King James Version.

CITIES OF REFUGE AND THE LEVITES · THE FORTY-EIGHT CITIES

Joshua 21 and 1 Chronicles 6:54–81, with each city's site and OpenBible.info's confidence in it

No.	Joshua 21	From	1 Chronicles 6	Site (OpenBible.info)	Score	Square	Notes
●	The sons of Aaron, the priests · 13 cities · Joshua 21:4, 9–19						
1	Hebron 21:11, 13	Judah and Simeon	Hebron 6:55, 57	Tel Rumeida	1000	D 10	The table follows Joshua 21 in its order: 48 cities (21:41), 13 for the sons of Aaron, 10 for the rest of the Kohathites, 13 for the Gershonites and 12 for the Merarites. 1 Chronicles 6:54–81 names 42 of them: it leaves out Juttah and Gibeon (Aaron), Eltekeh and Gibbethon (Kohath) and Jokneam and Kartah (Merari), gives 17 under another name or spelling, and sets Aijalon and Gath Rimmon among Ephraim’s cities, where Joshua 21:23–24 has them in Dan.
2	Libnah 21:13	Judah and Simeon	Libnah 6:57	Tell Bornat	381‡	B 10	
3	Jattir 21:14	Judah and Simeon	Jattir 6:57	Khirbet Attir	1000	C 11	
4	Eshtemoa 21:14	Judah and Simeon	Eshtemoa 6:57	As Samu	722	C 11	
5	Holon 21:15	Judah and Simeon	Hilen 6:58	Khirbet Alin	153‡	C 10	
6	Debir 21:15	Judah and Simeon	Debir 6:58	Khirbet Rabud	775	C 11	
7	Ain 21:16	Judah and Simeon	Ashan 6:59 (placed at Khirbet Asan, 442)	Tel Halif	46‡	B 11	
8	Juttah 21:16	Judah and Simeon	not named	Yatta	771	C 11	
9	Beth Shemesh 21:16	Judah and Simeon	Beth Shemesh 6:59	Tel Bet Shemesh	864	C 9	
10	Gibeon 21:17	Benjamin	not named	El Jib	912	D 9	
11	Geba 21:17	Benjamin	Geba 6:60	Jaba	740	D 9	
12	Anathoth 21:18	Benjamin	Anathoth 6:60	Ras el Kharruba	420‡	D 9	
13	Almon 21:18	Benjamin	Alemeth 6:60	Khirbet Almit	657‡	D 9	
■	The rest of the Kohathites · 10 cities · Joshua 21:5, 20–26						
14	Shechem 21:21	Ephraim	Shechem 6:67	Tell Balatah	1000	E 7	The tribal borders are the Allotment Map’s (Joshua 13–19): straight legs between the boundary towns and features the chapters name, at their OpenBible sites; a reconstruction, not a survey.
15	Gezer 21:21	Ephraim	Gezer 6:67	Tel Gezer	942	C 9	
16	Kibzaim 21:22	Ephraim	Jokmeam 6:68	Tel al Mazar	123‡	F 7	
17	Beth Horon 21:22	Ephraim	Beth Horon 6:68	Beit Ur al Tahta	1000	D 8	
18	Eltekeh 21:23	Dan	not named	Tel Shalaf	414‡	B 8	
19	Gibbethon 21:23	Dan	not named	Tell Melat	530‡	B 9	
20	Aijalon 21:24	Dan	Aijalon 6:69	Yalo	665‡	C 9	
21	Gath Rimmon 21:24	Dan	Gath Rimmon 6:69	Tel Gerisa	338‡	B 7	
22	Tanach 21:25	the half-tribe of Manasseh	Aner 6:70	Tell Ta’anakh	1000	D 5	
23	Gath Rimmon 21:25	the half-tribe of Manasseh	Bileam 6:70	Khirbet Belameh	365‡	E 5	
▲	The Gershonites · 13 cities · Joshua 21:6, 27–33						
24	Golan in Bashan 21:27	the other half of Manasseh, in Bashan	Golan in Bashan 6:71	Saham al Jawlan	680‡	H 3	The Salt Sea c. 2000 bc at 415 m below sea level: Migowski et al. 2006; Kagan et al. 2015; Frumkin 2009. Lake Huleh and its marsh restored after the surveys made before the drainage of 1951–58.
25	Be Eshterah 21:27	the other half of Manasseh, in Bashan	Ashtaroth 6:71	Tell Ashtara	602‡	H 3	
26	Kishion 21:28	Issachar	Kedesh 6:72	Tell Qisyon	447‡	E 4	
27	Daberath 21:28	Issachar	Daberath 6:72	Horvat Devora	673‡	E 4	
28	Jarmuth 21:29	Issachar	Ramoth 6:73	Kokab el Hawa	285‡	F 4	
29	En Gannim 21:29	Issachar	Anem 6:73	Khirbet Beit Jann	167‡	F 4	
30	Mishal 21:30	Asher	Mashal 6:74	Tell Keisan	466‡	D 3	
31	Abdon 21:30	Asher	Abdon 6:74	Tel Avdon	826	D 2	
32	Helkath 21:31	Asher	Hukok 6:75 (placed at Tel Regev, 201)	Tel Qashish	377‡	D 4	
33	Rehob 21:31	Asher	Rehob 6:75	Tell Bir el Gharbi	428‡	D 3	
34	Kedesh in Galilee 21:32	Naphtali	Kedesh in Galilee 6:76	Tel Kedesh	599‡	F 1	
35	Hammoth Dor 21:32	Naphtali	Hammon 6:76	Hamat Tiberias	483‡	F 3	
36	Kartan 21:32	Naphtali	Kirjathaim 6:76	Khirbet el Qureiyeh	397‡	F 1	
◆	The Merarites · 12 cities · Joshua 21:7, 34–40						
37	Jokneam 21:34	Zebulun	not named	Tel Yokneam	1000	D 4	NOTICES
38	Kartah 21:34	Zebulun	not named	Khirbet el Qureiyeh	104‡	not mapped	
39	Dimnah 21:35	Zebulun	Rimmon 6:77	Rumana	442‡	E 3	
40	Nahalal 21:35	Zebulun	Tabor 6:77 (placed at Iksal, 232)	Horbat Sefan	226‡	D 4	
41	Bezer 21:36	Reuben	Bezer in the wilderness 6:78	Umm el Amad	442‡	G 9	
42	Jahaz 21:36	Reuben	Jahzah 6:78	Khirbet el Medeiyineh	444‡	G 10	
43	Kedemoth 21:37	Reuben	Kedemoth 6:79	Aleiyan	251‡	G 11	
44	Mephaath 21:37	Reuben	Mephaath 6:79	Umm ar Rasas	465‡	G 11	
45	Ramoth in Gilead 21:38	Gad	Ramoth in Gilead 6:80	Tall er Rumeith	808	H 5	
46	Mahanaim 21:38	Gad	Mahanaim 6:80	Tell edh Dhahab el Gharbi	654‡	F 7	
47	Heshbon 21:39	Gad	Heshbon 6:81	Tell Hesban	433‡	G 9	
48	Jazer 21:39	Gad	Jazer 6:81	Khirbet Sara	281‡	G 8	
Scripture taken from the New King James Version®. Copyright © 1982 by Thomas Nelson. Used by permission. All rights reserved.							
Site positions adapted from the Bible Geocoding data at OpenBible.info (https://www.openbible.info/geo/), licensed under CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/). Uncertain identifications follow its best estimate.							
© DLR e.V. 2010–2014 and © Airbus Defence and Space GmbH 2014–2018 provided under COPERNICUS by the European Union and ESA; all rights reserved.							